

6. Romancing the stone

Make it sexy and you'll have a better chance of sticking with it. If some of the more elaborate ingredients are out of your budget reach, try keeping picnic supplies packed in your lunch bag (fabric napkin, sarong, good book). You can hit the park if there's one near your workplace. You could also try organizing a weekly or monthly potluck lunch at work, or a brown-bag buffet of simple sandwich items. Sign people up for ingredients like lunch meat, green peppers, sliced cheese, whatever. It's just important that everyone gets on board and commits to their assigned item.

7. Brown-bag theater

Make it a special event for coworkers who bring lunch. Decide on a time, and if there's a TV in the lunchroom, pick a show to follow. That'll give everyone a little extra motivation not to miss any fun by going out for lunch. Also, this could act as a support group, bringing a social aspect to a frugal lifestyle choice.

There's nothing wrong with adding a little spice to the brown-bag experience. It's one of the most powerful cash-carving strategies, and if

shaking it up a little is what will help you stick with the habit, go for it.

— **Myscha Theriault**



How to Save a Bundle with Assembly Cooking

Bulk cooking, once-a-month cooking (OAMC), assembly cooking . . . whatever you call it, the concept remains the same: doing a certain amount of prep work in advance in order to enjoy the convenience of meals on the fly later. While many retail options exist for this technique, the financial and flexibility benefits of tackling it at home can be significant. This article covers the strategies and infrastructure you will need.

WHAT YOU NEED

As with bulk buying and freezer saving, once-a-month cooking (OAMC) or bulk assembly cooking requires